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I start something, I know the endpoint. But I never announce the final destination or blueprint in the beginning. So what you see today is not what I worked for. It is a far bigger picture that will unfold. I work on a big canvas like an artist. I start at one point but at that time the final picture can't be seen." As an example, he points out that when work on the Bharat Mandapam started, no one else thought that the G20 summit held this September would happen there. But Modi was working with a plan. He says, "Whether I work towards making a new Parliament building or 40 million houses for the poor, I do it with equal planning and dedication."

The PM believes in the Indian version of exceptionalism. That India's manifest destiny is to be a great country, says NITI Aayog CEO B.V.R. Subrahmanyam

In between all this, there was Modi, the Vishwa Guru, who played the role of the balancer in a deeply divided and disorderly world. He converted what would have been a routine annual jamboree of world leaders into a grand spectacle. By holding the meetings of various G20 fora across 60 cities in 28 states, he got the Indian public involved and successfully bridged the gap between domestic discourse and foreign policy. Then Modi pulled off a diplomatic coup when he hammered out a consensus declaration even though the US and the West were aligned against China, Russia and others on key global issues including the contentious Ukraine war. By getting Africa, which has 55 nations, to become a member of the G20 during India's watch, Modi ensured that not only were the concerns of developing nations brought to the fore but also that India came to be seen as the voice of the Global South.

THE VISHWA GURU

By famously saying that this is not an era of war, the PM struck the right chord, getting both Russia and the US to appreciate India's approach while keeping the high moral ground. Asked how the Ukraine and Gaza wars could be settled, Modi in the interview called for "honest dialogue and sincere diplomacy as the preferred path to resolve differences, in an atmosphere that is free from fear and coercion". But he carefully nuanced his replies to ensure India's stand on terrorism and border intrusions is not diluted by saying, "Giving primacy to diplomacy does not mean that we compromise when it comes to terrorism and territorial integrity." India's relations with its neighbours are a mixed bag now, so without referring directly to the two bugbears, China and Pakistan, Modi said his way with them was "to be constructive and cooperative where required and, equally, to be firm and steadfast when needed".

Earlier, Modi pulled off one of the most successful visits by an Indian prime minister to the US when he and President Joe Biden signed a clutch of